yet to pass in Parliament. Yet, it was much higher than the historical pattern of women members who were elected to Parliament between 1957 and 2014 (see Figure 17.7). In a country where women MPs never made up even one-tenth of Parliament until even as late as 2009, the BJP's gambit of giving more tickets to women took it well above the national average on this gender yardstick.

A second marker of inclusiveness is the number of women included in leadership positions as ministers in the Union government. While Lok Sabha seats are about political winnability, ministerial positions represent the importance given to individuals and their social groups within a party. On this yardstick, Modi's two governments on average had a larger share of women ministers than Manmohan Singh's two governments that preceded it as well as Vajpayee's NDA regimes. The first full-term BJP-led government under Vajpayee (1999–2004) had a yearly average of 9 per cent women ministers. Manmohan Singh's UPA-1 and UPA-2 upped women's representation in the Union government's council of ministers to 11.2 per cent on average. Modi's NDA-1 and NDA-2 further increased women's share of ministerial portfolios to an average of 12.7 per cent. While the number of ministers kept changing with periodic reshuffles, the average yearly count tells the story of a growing gender balancing at the political level that started towards the end of Manmohan Singh's prime ministership and increased under Modi.

Figure 17.7: Women Have Historically Low Representation in Parliament: Women MPs in the Lok Sabha (1957–2019)